



> "G20 works with consensus, so **we'll have to work with all partner nations** to take our initiatives forward"
>
> **HARSH SHRINGLA**
> *G20's chief coordinator*

current global value chains, particularly those dependent on China. The country is in the middle of another crisis, as blank paper protests greet the drastic shutdowns of its major cities, including Shanghai. Since major manufacturers and investors cannot delink from China that easily, what is being contemplated is a China Plus One value chain, in which alternative countries can be identified to build global resilience. India has a major stake in being one of the alternative countries and will use the G20 opportunity to push its case. The country is also pushing for global norms that will enable the employment-intensive micro, small and medium enterprises (MSME) sector more access to funds. And to set up an Open Network for Digital Commerce as India's industries ministry has done to prevent digital commerce monopolies from stifling MSME growth. It will have to tread carefully, though, on issues such as food and energy security. Russia became its largest supplier of oil recently, besides fertilisers. The US and Europe are pushing for a price cap on Russian oil sales in the hope that it will bring down energy prices, especially for developing economies, and also limit the amount of revenue Russia will have at its disposal to wage its war on Ukraine. It's an issue that India will have to navigate with finesse.

With regard to food security, as wheat shipments get disrupted owing to major wheat producers Russia and Ukraine being locked in war, India is pushing for a revival of millet production across the world. Unlike wheat, which requires plenty of water, millets grow in water-scarce regions and were the staple in the Global South till they were supplanted by commercialised wheat production. However, almost 130 countries continue to grow millets, with India being the largest producer, accounting for 20 per cent of the total worldwide production of 89 million tonnes in 2019. In comparison, global wheat production stood at 800 million tonnes this year. India spearheaded a UN resolution last year to declare 2023 as the International Year of Millets, which was passed with the backing of 72 countries. At G20, it will push hard for countries to switch to millet production, helping the climate change cause too in the bargain, highlighting how it has a much lower carbon footprint and water usage than wheat.

DATA AS DEVELOPMENT

Another area where India hopes to play a leading role is in bridging the digital divide. Almost four billion people, or half the world's population, lack a digital identity. Two million people remain unbanked. And more than 130 of the world's 195 countries still do not have a digital payments system. India can lead by example on how to bring about an inclusive digital revolution. Through its JAM trinity—Jan Dhan bank accounts, Aadhar cards and Mobile networks—the government is able to execute what is probably the world's largest direct benefit transfer in cash for its welfare schemes. Over 400 million people have opened new bank accounts since the Modi government took over, reducing India's total unbanked population by half. Its public sector UPI (Unified Payments Interface) did a record 46.8 billion transactions last year, or 40 per cent of the world's real-time transactions. Says Kant: "We have built the world's best digital public infrastructure model that could be promoted at a global level, especially for developing countries. And we will advocate these solutions during our presidency."

The degree of success India will find in pushing various agendas remains to be seen. Giant card payment corporates such as Mastercard and Visa, for instance, will want a large share of the global pie and will resist India's bid to occupy the digital payments space. India is acutely aware of all these pulls and pressures and the fact that G20 is a norm-setting body, not an implementation one like, say, the UNSC. "The G20 works with consensus," says Harsh Shringla, G20's chief coordinator and a former foreign secretary, "so we will have to work with all our partner nations to take our initiatives forward. Decisions taken at G20 meetings are widely acceptable, given the all-encompassing nature of its membership." India will leave no stone unturned to ensure its year-long presidency enhances its stature as an emerging world power and helps it become the voice of the Global South. ■